

Vedic Age & Rise of the Mahajanapadas

From forest hymns to iron cities -- the birth of Indian thought

SSC CGL | Bank PO | RRB | UPSC Prelims

1500 BCE - 600 BCE

1500

BCE Vedic arrival

16

Mahajanapadas on map

4

Vedas to know
cold

4

Buddhist Councils held

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Exam Radar - Must-Know MCQ Facts

Quick Revision - 5-Minute Recap

Chapter 1 -- Transition: After Harappa, Before the Vedas

When the last Harappan city fell silent around 1300 BCE, the Indian subcontinent was not empty -- it was *restless*. Populations had shifted eastward into the Gangetic plains. New groups were arriving from the northwest through the Khyber and Bolan passes. The world's next great chapter was about to be written -- not in bricks and drains, but in **fire, hymn, and thought**.

These newcomers called themselves **Aryans** (Sanskrit: *Arya* = 'noble'). They brought a rich oral tradition -- sacred hymns that would become the Vedas -- and a pastoral way of life centred on cattle, horses, and the sacred fire

(Yagna). Their blending with existing populations gave rise to the **Vedic Age (1500-600 BCE)**.

Were Aryans 'invaders' or 'migrants'? Modern DNA evidence (2019 Rakhigarhi study) confirms a migration from Central Asia -- NOT a violent invasion. The old 'Aryan Invasion Theory' is now replaced by 'Aryan Migration Theory' in academic consensus.

Chapter 2 -- Early Vedic Age: The World of the Rigveda (1500-1000 BCE)

The Early Vedic period is understood through the **Rigveda** -- the oldest religious text in any Indo-European language. Its 1,028 hymns were memorised with extraordinary precision and passed from teacher to student for centuries without being written down. This is the era when India first found its voice -- and what it said still resonates today.

The Four Vedas -- Core Knowledge

Veda	Meaning	Content	Key Exam Fact
Rigveda	<i>Verses of Knowledge</i>	1,028 hymns (suktas) praising gods -- Indra, Agni, Varuna, Soma	OLDEST text in any Indo-European language. Mentions Sapta Sindhu (7 rivers).
Samaveda	<i>Veda of Melodies</i>	Rigvedic hymns set to musical notation for chanting during Soma sacrifice	Root of Indian classical music. Called 'the Veda of chanters'.
Yajurveda	<i>Veda of Sacrifice</i>	Prose + verse: instructions for ritual sacrifices. Two versions: Krishna & Shukla.	Used by Adhvaryu priests. Exists in two recensions.
Atharvaveda	<i>Veda of Atharvan</i>	Spells, charms, folk medicine, philosophy. Most 'worldly' of the four.	Added last to the Vedic canon. Reflects everyday life and popular religion.

Vedic Literature Beyond the 4 Vedas

Text Type	What It Is	Significance
Brahmanas	Prose texts explaining Vedic rituals and ceremonies	'Manual of rituals'; mark transition to priest-dominated society
Aranyakas	'Forest texts' -- philosophical works for forest hermits	Bridge between ritual (Brahmanas) and philosophy (Upanishads)
Upanishads (108)	Philosophical dialogues on Brahman, Atman, and Moksha	Called 'Vedanta' (end of Vedas). 'Satyameva Jayate' from Mundaka Upanishad.
Vedangas (6)	Auxiliary sciences: Shiksha, Kalpa, Vyakarana, Nirukta, Chandas, Jyotisha	Panini's Ashtadhyayi (grammar) -- world's first systematic grammar

Early Vedic Society & Geography

The Aryans settled in the **Sapta Sindhu** region -- land of seven rivers (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas, Sutlej and the dried Saraswati). This northwestern zone (Punjab-Haryana) was their homeland. Society was tribal,

mobile, and pastoral -- cattle was the primary measure of wealth.

Aspect	Early Vedic (1500-1000 BCE)
Social unit	Tribal (jana/vis); family=kula; village=grama; tribe=jana
Economy	Pastoral -- cattle herding dominant. Agriculture secondary. Barter trade.
Varna system	Originally flexible -- based on occupation, NOT birth. 4 varnas: Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra (from Purusha Sukta, Rigveda X.90)
Women's status	Relatively better -- could attend sabhas, compose hymns (Lopamudra, Gargi, Maitreyi), choose husbands (Swayamvara)
Political unit	Raja (king) -- not absolute. Assisted by Sabha (elders) and Samiti (tribal assembly). No standing army.
Key gods	Indra (most praised -- thunder/rain), Agni (fire), Varuna (cosmic order), Surya (sun), Soma (ritual drink). No idol worship.
Geography	Sapta Sindhu / Punjab. Main river: Sindhu (Indus). 'Aryavarta' = the noble land (NW India)

Chapter 3 -- Later Vedic Age: When Society Transformed (1000-600 BCE)

If the Early Vedic period was a campfire -- warm, intimate, tribal -- the Later Vedic period was a furnace. Iron tools cleared the dense Gangetic forests, agriculture became the backbone of the economy, and **society hardened into a rigid caste system** that would define India for millennia. Priests tightened their grip on ritual, women lost freedoms, and the seeds of Buddhism and Jainism were unwittingly planted.

Aspect	Early Vedic (1500-1000 BCE)	Later Vedic (1000-600 BCE)
Geography	Sapta Sindhu (NW India, Punjab)	Eastward -- Doab, Kuru-Panchala, Kosala, Videha (Gangetic plains)
Economy	Pastoral -- cattle primary	Agricultural -- iron plough, rice cultivation. Land = wealth
Varna	Flexible, occupation-based	Rigid, birth-based. Brahmin supremacy. Untouchability emerges.
Women's status	Relatively free -- Sabha access, hymn composers	Declined -- excluded from assemblies; child marriage begins
Political system	Tribal; Sabha + Samiti powerful	Larger kingdoms; hereditary kingship; Sabha/Samiti lose power
Religious shift	Nature worship, simple Yajnas	Elaborate rituals: Ashvamedha, Rajasuya, Vajapeya. Priests indispensable. Idol worship begins.
Iron use	No iron evidence	Iron (Shyama Ayas) -- axes, ploughs, weapons. Transformed agriculture and warfare.
Key texts	Rigveda	Sama, Yajur, Atharvaveda; Brahmanas; Aranyakas; Upanishads
Reaction	--	Buddhism, Jainism, Upanishadic philosophy arise to challenge ritual excess

3 key Later Vedic rituals for exams:

Ashvamedha -- horse sacrifice to assert a king's sovereignty.

Rajasuya -- royal consecration / coronation ceremony.

Vajapeya -- 'drink of strength'; chariot race + Soma sacrifice.

Chapter 4 -- The 16 Mahajanapadas: India's First Political Map (600-325 BCE)

By 600 BCE, tribal units had grown into 16 large kingdoms and republics -- the **Shodasha Mahajanapadas**. This was India's first organised political geography. The list comes from two Buddhist texts: **Anguttara Nikaya** and **Mahaparinibbana Sutta**. Government exams test 3-4 of these every year by capital city or modern-day location.

Mahajanapada	Capital	Region (Modern)	Why It Matters
Magadha	<i>Rajgriha</i> -> <i>Pataliputra</i>	Bihar	Most powerful -- became India's first empire. Base of Bimbisara and Ajatashatru.

Kosala	<i>Shravasti</i>	Eastern UP	Birthplace of Rama (Ayodhya). Rival to Magadha. Buddha spent most teaching years here.
Vajji (republic)	<i>Vaishali</i>	North Bihar	World's FIRST republic (Gana-sangha). Licchavi clan. Birthplace of Mahavira.
Kuru	<i>Indraprastha / Hastinapura</i>	Haryana-Delhi	Mahabharata setting. Ancient heartland of Vedic culture.
Panchala	<i>Ahichatra (N) / Kampilya (S)</i>	Western UP	Merged with Kuru culturally. Draupadi's home (Drupada was king).
Avanti	<i>Ujjain (N) / Mahishmati (S)</i>	Madhya Pradesh	One of 4 powerful kingdoms. Later absorbed by Magadha.
Vatsa	<i>Kaushambi</i>	Allahabad area, UP	King Udayana -- Buddhist connections. Absorbed by Avanti, then Magadha.
Anga	<i>Champa</i>	Bhagalpur, Bihar	Conquered by Bimbisara -- Magadha's FIRST expansion move.
Gandhara	<i>Taxila / Pushkalavati</i>	NW Pakistan / Afghanistan	Taxila = ancient university. Crossroads of Persian and Greek cultural contact.
Kamboja	<i>Rajapura / Hataka</i>	NW (Afghanistan-Kashmir)	Famous for horses. Often mentioned alongside Gandhara.
Malla (republic)	<i>Kushinara / Pava</i>	Eastern UP	Buddha attained Mahaparinirvana at Kushinara. Republic state.
Chedi	<i>Shuktimati</i>	Bundelkhand, MP	Sisupala's kingdom (Mahabharata). Mentioned in Buddhist literature.
Surasena	<i>Mathura</i>	Mathura, UP	Krishna's homeland. Visited by Megasthenes. Strong Buddhist influence.
Assaka	<i>Potana / Podana</i>	Nandura, Maharashtra	ONLY Mahajanapada south of the Vindhyas. On the Godavari river.
Matsya	<i>Viratanagara</i>	Rajasthan (Jaipur area)	Pandavas' hiding place (Mahabharata). Minor political role.
Kasi (variant)	<i>Varanasi</i>	Varanasi, UP	Some texts list Kasi instead of other entries. Know both variants for exams.

The 4 most powerful Mahajanapadas (always exam-tested): Magadha, Kosala, Avanti, Vatsa. Magadha eventually swallowed all three.
Republic states (Gana-Sanghas): Vajji (Vaishali), Malla (Kushinara), Kamboja, Licchavi.

Chapter 5 -- Rise of Magadha: India's First Superpower

Of all the 16 Mahajanapadas, only one would survive and grow to swallow the rest. Magadha's rise is a story of **geography, iron, ambition, and strategic brilliance**. Understanding WHY Magadha rose is as important as knowing which rulers made it happen.

Magadha's Advantage	Explanation
Iron-rich soil	Southern Bihar has large iron ore deposits -- superior weapons AND iron ploughs for agriculture
River geography	Ganga, Son, and Champa rivers -- natural defence + trade highways. Pataliputra at river confluence = economic hub
Fertile plains	High agricultural surplus -- large army, large treasury
Elephant forests	Forests of Chhota Nagpur provided war elephants -- decisive military advantage
Aggressive rulers	Bimbisara, Ajatashatru -- relentless expansionists with diplomatic and military networks

Key Rulers of Magadha -- The Dynasty Timeline

Ruler	Dynasty	Period	Key Achievements
Bimbisara	Haryanka	544-492 BCE	Founded Magadha's imperial ambition. Conquered Anga (first expansion). Marriage alliances with Licchavis and Kosala. Contemporary of Buddha -- became a disciple. Capital: Rajgriha.
Ajatashatru	Haryanka	492-460 BCE	Killed father Bimbisara (Pitrahanta = father-killer). Defeated Vajji republic + Kosala. Used Mahashilakantaka (catapult) and Rathamusala (chariot with blades). Convened 1st Buddhist Council at Rajgriha (483 BCE).
Udayin	Haryanka	460-440 BCE	Founded Pataliputra (modern Patna) as new capital at Ganga-Son confluence -- remained India's capital for 1,000+ years.
Shishunaga	Shishunaga	412-394 BCE	Destroyed Pradyota dynasty of Avanti -- absorbed Avanti into Magadha. Major expansion.
Kalashoka	Shishunaga	394-366 BCE	Convened 2nd Buddhist Council at Vaishali (383 BCE) -- addressed schism in Buddhist sangha.
Mahapadma Nanda	Nanda	344-323 BCE	First 'historical' emperor of India. Called 'Destroyer of all Kshatriyas'. Built India's first large professional standing army (200,000 infantry). Greatest territorial extent before Mauryas.
Dhana Nanda	Nanda	323-321 BCE	Last Nanda ruler. His arrogance toward Chandragupta directly caused the Nanda dynasty's downfall. Overthrown by Chandragupta + Chanakya.

Dynasty order in Magadha: Haryanka -> Shishunaga -> Nanda -> Maurya.

Mnemonic: 'Hungry Snakes Never Miss' (H-S-N-M)

Pataliputra (Patna) was founded by UDAYIN -- not by Chandragupta Maurya.

Chapter 6 -- The Buddha's Revolution: Rise of Buddhism

Around 500 BCE, a prince sat under a Bodhi tree in Bodh Gaya and, in one night of profound meditation, understood the nature of suffering. His name was **Siddhartha Gautama**, and his insight would change the moral landscape of Asia forever. Buddhism was not merely a religion -- it was India's first great *social revolution*, one that challenged caste, priesthood, and ritual with the radical idea that liberation comes from within.

Event	Place	Significance
Birth	<i>Lumbini, Nepal</i>	Born ~563 BCE. Father: King Suddhodana (Shakya clan). Mother: Mahamaya. Raised by Mahaprajapati Gautami.
The Four Sights	<i>Outside Kapilavastu</i>	Old man, sick man, corpse, and wandering monk -- triggered his quest to end suffering
Great Renunciation	<i>Kapilavastu</i>	Age 29 -- left wife Yashodhara, son Rahul, and royal palace. Called 'Mahabhinishkramana'.
Enlightenment	<i>Bodh Gaya, Bihar</i>	Under the Peepal (Bodhi) tree, age 35. Became 'The Awakened One' -- the Buddha.
First Sermon	<i>Sarnath (near Varanasi)</i>	'Turning of the Wheel of Dharma' (Dhammachakkapavattana). Preached Four Noble Truths + Eightfold Path to five disciples.
Mahaparinirvana	<i>Kushinagar, UP</i>	483 BCE, age 80. Died under Sal trees after meal at Cunda the blacksmith's home.

Core Buddhist Teachings -- Exam Must-Know

Teaching	Content
Four Noble Truths	1. Dukkha -- life is suffering 2. Samudaya -- suffering has a cause (desire) 3. Nirodha -- suffering can end 4. Magga -- there is a path to end it
Eightfold Path	Right View, Intention, Speech, Action, Livelihood, Effort, Mindfulness, Concentration. Called the 'Middle Path' -- avoiding extremism and indulgence.
Three Jewels (Tri-Ratna)	Buddha (the teacher) + Dhamma (the teaching) + Sangha (the community of monks)
Three Marks of Existence	Anicca (impermanence) + Dukkha (suffering) + Anatta (no permanent self / no soul)
Nirvana	Ultimate goal -- extinguishing desire, liberation from the rebirth cycle (samsara). NOT a heaven -- it is cessation of the cycle.
Rejected	Caste system + Vedic authority + animal sacrifice + idol worship (early Buddhism) + soul (Atman) concept. Buddha was agnostic on God's existence ('Noble Silence').
Language	Pali -- language of common people (not Sanskrit of Brahmins). Deliberately inclusive.

Four Buddhist Councils -- Exam Favourite Table

Council	Year	Place	Patron	President / Outcome
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1st Council	483 BCE	Rajgriha (Sattapanni cave)	Ajatashatru	President: Mahakassapa. Compiled Vinaya Pitaka (Upali) and Sutta Pitaka (Ananda).
2nd Council	383 BCE	Vaishali	Kalashoka	President: Sabakami. Schism over 10 monastic rules -> Sthaviravada vs Mahasanghika split.
3rd Council	250 BCE	Pataliputra	Ashoka (Maurya)	President: Moggaliputta Tissa. Compiled Abhidhamma Pitaka (completes Tripitaka). Spread Buddhism to Sri Lanka, Greece, Egypt.
4th Council	72 CE	Kundalvana, Kashmir	Kanishka (Kushana)	Chairman: Vasumitra; Ashvaghosha. Led to Hinayana vs Mahayana split.

Buddhist Texts & Three Major Sects

Category	Name / Detail
Tripitaka (Three Baskets)	Vinaya Pitaka (monastic rules) + Sutta Pitaka (Buddha's discourses) + Abhidhamma Pitaka (philosophical analysis). Written in Pali.
Hinayana ('Lesser Vehicle')	Original conservative form. Individual liberation (Arhat ideal). Pali texts. Followed in Sri Lanka, Thailand, Myanmar.
Mahayana ('Greater Vehicle')	Reformed school -- universal salvation (Bodhisattva ideal). Sanskrit texts. Idol worship introduced. Spread to China, Japan, Korea.
Vajrayana ('Thunderbolt')	Tantric Buddhism from Bengal/Bihar (Pala period). Spread to Tibet.
Jataka Tales	Stories of Buddha's 547 previous lives -- key source for ancient Indian social history.

Chapter 7 -- Mahavira and Jainism: The Path of Ahimsa

At almost the same time as the Buddha, another great teacher walked the dusty roads of the Gangetic plains -- **Vardhamana Mahavira**. His message was equally radical but took a different form: *absolute non-violence*. Where the Buddha offered a middle path, Mahavira demanded total renunciation. Jainism is one of the world's oldest living religions, and its influence on Indian philosophy, art, and ethics is immeasurable.

Event	Place	Significance
Birth	<i>Vaishali (Kundagrama), Bihar</i>	Born 599 BCE. Father: Siddhartha (Licchavi clan). Mother: Trishala. Called 'Vardhamana' at birth.
Renunciation	<i>Age 30</i>	Left home after parents' death. Became ascetic -- pulled out hair in 5 handfuls (Panchavajra -- unique Jain practice).
Enlightenment	<i>Jrimbhikagrama, Bihar</i>	After 12 years of rigorous asceticism, attained Kevala Jnana (omniscience) under a Sal tree. Became 'Mahavira' (Great Hero) and 'Jina' (Conqueror).
Death (Nirvana)	<i>Pavapuri, Bihar</i>	527 BCE, age 72. Attained Moksha -- considered the last Tirthankara (Ford-maker).

Core Jain Teachings

Teaching	Content
Five Mahavratas (Great Vows)	1. Ahimsa (non-violence -- most important) 2. Satya (truth) 3. Asteya (non-stealing) 4. Brahmacharya (celibacy -- added by Mahavira) 5. Aparigraha (non-possession). Original 4 by Parshvanatha; Mahavira added Brahmacharya.
Triratna (Three Jewels)	1. Samyak Darshana (Right Faith) 2. Samyak Jnana (Right Knowledge) 3. Samyak Charitra (Right Conduct). Path to Moksha.
Anekantavada	'Many-sidedness of truth' -- no single perspective captures full reality. Unique Jain philosophical concept.
Syadvada	'Doctrine of conditional predication' -- all statements conditionally true. Related to Anekantavada.
Soul (Jiva)	Jainism BELIEVES in the soul (unlike Buddhism). Every living being has a Jiva -- even insects and plants. Hence extreme non-violence.
Language	Ardha-Magadhi (Prakrit) -- accessible to common people of eastern Gangetic plains

24 Tirthankaras & Key Jain Sects

Detail	Fact
1st Tirthankara	Rishabha (Adinatha) -- mentioned in the Rigveda and Vishnu Purana; symbol: the bull
23rd Tirthankara	Parshvanatha -- historically recognised; lived 250 years before Mahavira. Taught 4 Mahavratas (without Brahmacharya)
24th Tirthankara	Mahavira -- the most recent and best known. 'The reformer and reorganiser' of Jainism

Jain sects	Digambara (sky-clad -- monks wear no clothes) vs Shvetambara (white-clad -- monks wear white robes). Split ~1st century CE.
Sallekhana	Ritual fasting to death -- considered the most honourable Jain death for elderly monks

Chapter 8 -- Buddhism vs Jainism: Side-by-Side Comparison

Both arose in the Gangetic plains, in the same era (~500 BCE), challenged the same system (Brahminical orthodoxy), and attracted the same social base (Vaishyas, Kshatriyas). Yet they arrived at very different conclusions. Examiners love this comparison -- expect 2-3 MCQs directly from this table.

Aspect	Buddhism	Jainism
Founder	Siddhartha Gautama (Buddha)	Vardhamana Mahavira (24th Tirthankara)
Birthplace	Lumbini, Nepal	Vaishali (Kundagrama), Bihar
Soul (Atman)	DENIED -- no permanent self (Anatta)	AFFIRMED -- every living being has a Jiva (soul)
God / Creator	Agnostic -- Noble Silence on God's existence	No creator God -- Tirthankaras are liberated souls, not God
Asceticism	Middle Path -- neither extreme luxury nor extreme austerity	Extreme asceticism encouraged -- Digambaras practice total nudity
Ahimsa	Important but not absolute -- monks could eat meat if 'three pure' conditions met	Absolute -- even plants have souls; extreme dietary restrictions
Ultimate goal	Nirvana -- extinguishing desire and cycle of rebirth	Moksha -- liberation of soul from all karma
Language	Pali	Ardha-Magadhi Prakrit
Spread	International -- Sri Lanka, China, Japan, SE Asia, Central Asia	Mainly within India -- Gujarat, Rajasthan, Karnataka
Royal patronage	Bimbisara, Ajatashatru, Ashoka, Kanishka, Harsha	Bimbisara, Chandragupta Maurya (later life), Kharavela
Sacred texts	Tripitaka (Pali Canon) -- Vinaya + Sutta + Abhidhamma	Agamas (12 Angas + Upangas) -- Ardha-Magadhi

EXAM RADAR -- Must-Know Facts

- * Vedic Age split: Early (1500-1000 BCE, NW India, tribal) vs Later (1000-600 BCE, Gangetic, agricultural).
- * Rigveda is the oldest text in any Indo-European language -- direct one-liner MCQ answer.
- * Satyameva Jayate is from the Mundaka Upanishad -- NOT directly from a Veda.
- * Aryan Migration Theory (not Invasion) -- DNA evidence 2019 (Rakhigarhi) is current consensus.
- * 16 Mahajanapadas listed in Anguttara Nikaya (Buddhist text). Only Assaka is south of Vindhya.
- * The 4 most powerful Mahajanapadas: Magadha, Kosala, Avanti, Vatsa.
- * Vajji (Vaishali) is the world's first republic -- the Licchavi Gana-Sangha.
- * Bimbisara first expanded Magadha by conquering ANGA -- always asked.
- * Ajatashatru killed his father Bimbisara -- called 'Pitrahanta' (father-killer).

- * Pataliputra (Patna) was founded by UDAYIN -- NOT Chandragupta Maurya.
- * Dynasty order: Haryanka -> Shishunaga -> Nanda -> Maurya. Mnemonic: 'Hungry Snakes Never Miss'.
- * 1st Buddhist Council: Rajgriha (483 BCE), patron Ajatashatru, president Mahakassapa.
- * 3rd Buddhist Council: Pataliputra (250 BCE), patron Ashoka, president Moggaliputta Tissa.
- * 4th Buddhist Council: Kashmir (72 CE), patron Kanishka -- led to Hinayana vs Mahayana split.
- * Buddha's three key places: Birth=Lumbini, Enlightenment=Bodh Gaya, First Sermon=Sarnath, Death=Kushinagar.
- * Mahavira was NOT the founder of Jainism -- he was the 24th Tirthankara and a reformer.
- * Mahavira added Brahmacharya to Parshvanatha's 4 Mahavratas to make 5 Mahavratas.
- * Buddhism: NO soul (Anatta). Jainism: YES soul (Jiva). This is the biggest doctrinal difference.
- * Digambara = sky-clad (no clothes). Shvetambara = white-clad. -- Direct MCQ in every exam.
- * Three Buddhist sects: Hinayana (Pali, individual liberation), Mahayana (Sanskrit, universal), Vajrayana (Tantric).

Quick Revision -- 5-Minute Recap Before the Exam

Vedic phases	Early (1500-1000 BCE, NW, tribal, pastoral, Rigveda) -> Later (1000-600 BCE, Gangetic, agricultural, rigid caste, elaborate rituals).
4 Vedas	Rigveda (oldest, hymns) + Samaveda (music) + Yajurveda (sacrifice) + Atharvaveda (spells, everyday). Then: Brahmanas -> Aranyakas -> Upanishads.
Vedic society shift	Early: flexible varna, women free, Sabha/Samiti powerful. Later: rigid caste by birth, women restricted, king absolute, iron tools.
16 Mahajanapadas	Magadha (Bihar) most powerful. Kosala (Shravasti). Vajji (Vaishali, 1st republic). Avanti (Ujjain). Only Assaka south of Vindhyas.
Magadha dynasties	Haryanka: Bimbisara (expansion) -> Ajatashatru (patricide, military). Shishunaga: absorbed Avanti. Nanda: huge army. Overthrown by Chandragupta.
Buddhism	Lumbini (born) -> Bodh Gaya (enlightened) -> Sarnath (1st sermon) -> Kushinagar (died). 4 Noble Truths + 8 Fold Path. 4 Councils.
Jainism	Mahavira: 24th Tirthankara. Born Vaishali. 5 Mahavratas (Ahimsa most important). Triratna. Anekantavada. Digambara vs Shvetambara.
Key contrast	Buddhism: no soul, middle path, Pali, international spread. Jainism: has soul, extreme asceticism, Ardha-Magadhi, India-centric.